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RAHUL GANDHI
Congress leader

REWRITING A LEGACY

Paving the way for the first non-Gandhi Congress president in over two decades and embarking on an unprecedented mass-connect drive on foot...in 2022, Rahul proved he means business

By Kaushik Deka

In 2019, when Rahul Gandhi quit as the Congress president, he had lamented he didn't get enough support from senior party leaders in the political battle against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP. He also made it clear that neither he nor the other two Gandhis—mother Sonia and sister Priyanka—would occupy the top party post. In 2022, the Gandhi scion proved that he meant business as the Congress's 'first family' paved the way for the election of a non-Gandhi party president after over two decades. In the process, Rahul has not only freed himself from organisational responsibilities, but is apparently also seeking to escape the blame for the party's repeated electoral debacles. He did not campaign at all during the Himachal Pradesh assembly polls and addressed only a handful of public rallies for two days in Gujarat.

Instead, Rahul focused on what he has been planning to do for several years—distancing himself from the Congress legacy that has wiped the party out of the national mindspace. At the Udaipur *Chintan Shivir* in May, Rahul—in a veiled attack on those at the helm during the scam-riddled UPA-2 era—made a distinction between himself and several other Congress leaders, claiming that he was not afraid of Modi because he never indulged in corruption. It's a different matter that, a month later, the party hit the streets protesting against the ED for questioning Rahul and Sonia on allegations of money laundering in the National Herald case.

Meanwhile, Rahul has embarked on a new journey—a 3,500-km foot march called Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY) to traverse the country from Kanyakumari to Kashmir. This unique experiment in post-Independence India is not just an exercise in mass connect, but a reinvention of Rahul as a political leader. It's a mission to showcase that he is a serious, full-time politician, who can stay in a truck-mounted container and walk more than 20 km every day, braving heat, rain, cold, dust and ridicule from the opponents while knowing very well that immediate electoral dividends could be next to nothing. The response in the virtual world has been overwhelming. The party has also been able to pull crowds, with a decent dose of intellectuals and celebrities, in every state that the BJY has touched. But the real challenge remains the same—will this new Rahul be able to win votes for the Congress? ■

3,500

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The distance to be covered by Rahul-led Bharat Jodo Yatra